

Chapter Seventeen

BUDDHISM AND VEDĀNTA

Comprehensive Study Notes

from C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

“Buddhism and Vedānta should not be viewed as two opposed systems but only as different stages in the development of the same central thought which starts with the Upaniṣads, finds its indirect support in Buddha, its elaboration in Mahāyāna Buddhism, its open revival in Gauḍapāda, which reaches its zenith in Śaṅkara and culminates in the Post-Śaṅkarites.”

Roadmap of the Chapter

- I. The governing thesis — similarities overwhelming, differences few and mostly not vital.
- II. Buddha and Vedānta — intellect vs. immediate realization; the Lamp of Dharma borrowed from the Upaniṣads.
- III. Aśvaghoṣa and Vedānta — Tathatā identified with Ātman/Brahman.
- IV. Śūnyavāda and Vedānta — Śūnya as Māyā and Brahman; difference of emphasis only.
- V. Vijñānavāda and Vedānta — absolute idealism and its full terminological correspondence with Vedānta.
- VI. Svatantra-Vijñānavāda and Vedānta — where Śaṅkara's criticism is valid, and why.
- VII. Nairātmyavāda — the denial of the empirical ego, not of the true Ātman.
- VIII Kṣaṇa-bhaṅga-vāda — momentariness as a doctrine of phenomena, not of Reality.
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- IX. A historical survey — from the Upaniṣads through Dignāga's fateful turn to Śaṅkara's final blow.

SECTION I

The Governing Thesis

Buddhism and Vedānta, Sharma insists at the very outset, must not be viewed as two mutually opposed systems, but as successive stages in the unfolding of one and the same central thought — a thought that originates in the Upaniṣads, receives indirect support from the Buddha himself, is elaborated in Mahāyāna Buddhism, undergoes an open revival in Gauḍapāda, reaches its zenith in Śaṅkara, and culminates in the Post-Śaṅkarites.

So far as the **similarities** between Buddhism and Vedānta are concerned, Sharma states, they are so many and so strong that “by no stretch of imagination can they be denied or explained otherwise.” So far as the **differences** are concerned, they are few, and mostly not vital — most of them resting, in Sharma's judgment, on a grave misunderstanding of Buddhism, which the chapter sets out to remove. He concedes, however, that some differences are real and vital, though very few, and undertakes to point them out. (These prove, in Sections VII-VIII, to be Nairātmyavāda and Kṣaṇa-bhaṅga-vāda — and even these, on Sharma's analysis, turn out to be far less radical differences than they are conventionally taken to be.)

SECTION II

Buddha and Vedānta

The fundamental philosophical doctrine that the Buddha borrows from the Upaniṣads is that **intellect**, being essentially relational — that is, operating always through the knower-known relation — inevitably involves itself in insoluble antinomies. In order to become one with Reality, intellect has to be transformed into immediate Spiritual Experience: *bodhi* or *prajñā*. Intellect, as a matter of fact, is Pure Knowledge itself; it only *appears* to be intellect on account of Ignorance (*avidyā*). Reality is therefore not to be philosophized about — it is to be directly realized.

The Unborn, Uncreated and Imperishable Reality is throughout implied by all changing phenomena as their background, and, at the same time, it transcends all phenomena — all the dualism (*ubho ante*, “both ends”) of the intellect, as well as the very trinity of knower, known and knowledge. It is Pure Consciousness, and it is to be directly realized by the wise. People are surrounded by the darkness of ignorance; they have to look for the lamp of knowledge — and it is precisely this Lamp of Dharma, borrowed from the Upaniṣads, that the Buddha bequeaths to them.

Sharma cites Mrs. Rhys Davids' A Manual of Buddhism (p. 194): “The Sākyan mission was out ‘not to destroy, but to fulfil’, to enlarge and enhance the accepted faith-in-God of their day, not by asseverating, but by making it more vital.”

SECTION III

Aśvaghoṣa and Vedānta

Aśvaghoṣa realized that, after the Buddha's Nirvāṇa, his teachings were perverted by the Hīnayānists, who reduced mind to fleeting ideas and matter to fleeting sensations, who placed the Buddha in the position of God, and who denied the ultimate existence of both mind and matter. Aśvaghoṣa challenged the Hīnayānists and refuted their views. He knew well that the Buddha's real philosophy was based on the Upaniṣads, and he tried to revive it.

The Identity of Tathatā with Ātman/Brahman

The *Tathatā* ("Suchness") of Aśvaghoṣa — also called *Bhūta-tathatā*, *Tathāgatagarbha*, *Dharmakāya*, *Dharmadhātu*, *Ālaya-vijñāna*, *Bodhi* or *Prajñā* — is, Sharma argues, in fact the very same as the Ātman or the Brahman of the Upaniṣads. His case rests on a cluster of parallels:

- **Relativity and the Absolute.** Relativity (*pratītyasamutpāda*) is the realm of the intellect, itself a product of *Avidyā*; the Absolute is wholly untouched by it. Aśvaghoṣa: "It is wrong to take the work of Ignorance as ultimate and to forget the foundation on which it stands."

Suzuki, Outlines of Mahāyāna Buddhism, p. 124.

- **The two-aspect structure.** The *Tathatā* of Aśvaghoṣa — which is *Bodhi* or *Vijñāna* or Pure Consciousness — has, together with itself, two aspects: the Absolute 'Suchness' and the conditional 'suchness.' This reminds us at once of the Ātman or Brahman of the Upaniṣads with its own two aspects — the higher and the lower, or the *nirguṇa/para* and the *saguṇa/apara*.
- **Indescribability.** Both the *Tathatā* and the Brahman are *jñānaghana* (a mass of consciousness) and *anirvacanīya*, or indescribable, in the sense that intellect fails to grasp them fully.
- **Ignorance and the two standpoints.** Aśvaghoṣa's 'Ignorance' is the very *avidyā* of the Upaniṣads; his phenomenal and absolute standpoints are the *vyāvahārika* and *pāramārthika* standpoints of the Upaniṣads.
- **Shared similes.** Aśvaghoṣa uses precisely the similes commonly used in the Upaniṣads — the similes of waves and water, of pots and clay, of ornaments and gold.

It is, Sharma concludes, unmistakably clear that the Upaniṣads exercised a great influence on Aśvaghoṣa. Avoiding all the self-contradictions of Hīnayāna, Aśvaghoṣa has rightly interpreted the Buddha in the light of the Upaniṣads and has placed Buddhism on a firm basis.

SECTION IV

Śūnyavāda and Vedānta**Śūnya Does Not Mean Nihilism**

Sharma's exposition of Śūnyavāda (developed at length in the preceding chapter) is said to make clear at once how similar it is to Vedānta. It has already been clearly proved that *śūnya* does not mean a mere negation, nor does Śūnyavāda mean nihilism. Śūnya is used in a double sense: it means **Māyā** as well as **Brahman**.

- **Empirically** (in the sense of Māyā): all *dharma*s, or world-experiences — subjective as well as objective — are *svabhāva-śūnya*, devoid of ultimate reality. They are *pratītya-samutpanna*, merely relative. They are ultimately unreal because they can be called neither existent nor non-existent nor both. They are indescribable, or *māyā*.
- But the very fact that they are appearances implies that there must be a Reality of which they are mere appearances. This Reality, or *tattva*, is *prapañcaśūnya* — beyond all plurality. It is like Brahman. It is *Bodhi*, or Pure Consciousness. It is indescribable, or *catuṣkoṭivinirmukta*, because all categories of the intellect fail to grasp it fully.

Correspondence of Standpoints

Samvṛti and *paramārtha* correspond to *vyavahāra* and *paramārtha* of Vedānta. Candrakīrti further divides *samvṛti* into *mithyā-samvṛti* and *tathya-samvṛti*, to match the *parikalpita* and *paratantra* of Vijñānavāda. *Mithyā-samvṛti*, *tathya-samvṛti* and *paramārtha* then correspond exactly to *pratibhāsa*, *vyavahāra* and *paramārtha* of Vedānta. The two standpoints, empirical and absolute, are found in the Upaniṣads themselves, which sometimes use the very word '*samvṛti*' too.

E.g., Bṛhadāraṇyaka, II, 5, 18.

The Illusion-Similes Are Not Nihilistic

The Mahāyāna-sūtras, Nāgārjuna and his followers condemn all phenomena as being like illusion, mirage, the 'son of a barren woman', a 'sky-flower', etc. — expressions which suggest that phenomena are something absolutely unreal. But this, Sharma insists, is not their intention: such expressions are used only to emphasize the ultimate unreality of phenomena, whose empirical reality is, as already shown, emphatically maintained. Gauḍapāda and even Śaṅkara themselves use exactly such expressions — they are therefore not to be condemned as teaching absolute unreality either.

The Enormous Similarity of Dialectical Method

Sharma stresses the enormous similarities between the Śūnyavādins on the one hand and Gauḍapāda, Śaṅkara and the Post-Śaṅkarites on the other: their dialectical arguments are essentially similar, and their method is essentially the same. Intellect or logic has only negative value for both — it has to be transformed into immediate experience so that it may embrace the Absolute. Both are interested in showing their opponents that, even according to the opponents' own canons of logic, the opponents' own arguments can be proved false. Ultimate Reality is Silence: it has to be realized

directly; it cannot be discussed. If the opponent accepts this position, he is accepting their view; if he challenges it, he is challenging the validity of his own logic. Intellect is essentially discursive or relational: it must work with its own concepts and categories, and so it can give only the relative world, which must be taken to be empirically real. Ultimately, however, this relative world is false, because it is neither existent, nor non-existent, nor both. The rejection of all views is, therefore, itself not a *view*; it is an attempt to rise above thought altogether.

Gauḍapāda's and Śaṅkara's Reception of Śūnyavāda

Gauḍapāda frankly approves the No-origination (*ajāti*) theory preached by Śūnyavāda; his Kārikās bear striking resemblance to the Kārikās of Nāgārjuna. Śaṅkara knows very well that Śūnyavāda cannot be criticized on its true merits, and so he simply dismisses it by taking the word *śūnya* in its popular sense of negation, dubbing Śūnyavāda a self-condemned nihilism. Śaṅkara says that Śūnyavāda has no right to condemn this world as unreal unless it takes recourse to some higher reality (*anyat-tattva*) — but, Sharma points out, Śūnyavāda **does** take recourse to precisely this higher reality. Nāgārjuna himself uses the very word '*tattva*' and defines it as that which is to be directly realized, which is calm and blissful, where all plurality is merged, where all the cries of intellect are satisfied, and which is the non-dual Absolute.

Mādhyamika-Kārikā, XVIII, 9.

Most of the Post-Śaṅkarites, following Śaṅkara, either condemn Śūnyavāda as nihilism, or else say that if *śūnya* really means the indescribable *māyā*, they have no quarrel with it. Śrīharṣa frankly admits that Śūnyavāda cannot be criticized, because it is similar to Vedānta. The only difference he points out between Śūnyavāda and Vedānta is that while Śūnyavāda declares even Consciousness to be unreal, Vedānta makes an exception in its favour. Śrīharṣa quotes a verse from the Laṅkāvatāra (II, 175): 'All things which can be known by the intellect have no reality of their own. These are therefore said to be indescribable and unreal.'

Khaṇḍana, p. 31.

But, Sharma counters, we know that the Laṅkāvatāra itself repeatedly makes an exception in favour of Consciousness. Śūnyavāda condemns only the **individual self** to be unreal, not Pure Consciousness. Nāgārjuna's own definition of Reality clearly shows that it can apply only to Pure Consciousness: Nāgārjuna himself, in his *Ratnāvalī* (I, 45 and 60), identifies Reality with Pure Consciousness, or *Bodhi*, or *Jñāna*. Āryadeva likewise identifies Reality with the Pure Self, or *Chitta*.

Chittaviśuddhi-prakaraṇa, 27, 28, 74.

Śāntideva, in much-inspired verses, praises the only Reality — the *Bodhi-chitta*, or the True Self, which is Pure Consciousness.

Bodhicharyāvatāra, I, 8, 10, etc.

If the *Bodhi* of Nāgārjuna, the *Chitta* of Āryadeva, and the *Bodhi-chitta* of Śāntideva are not the self-luminous Self which is Pure Consciousness, Sharma asks, "what else on earth can they be?"

The Only Real Difference: One of Emphasis Alone

The only difference between Śūnyavāda and Vedānta is, therefore, a difference of emphasis — and this difference is of a double nature:

- **First:** while Śūnyavāda is more keen to emphasize the ultimate unreality of all phenomena, Śaṅkara and his followers are more keen to emphasize the empirical reality of all phenomena; and
- **Second:** while Śūnyavāda is less keen to develop the conception of ultimate Reality, Vedānta is more keen to develop this conception almost to perfection.

This is not unnatural, Sharma remarks, if we remember that Śūnyavāda represents the earlier stage, while Vedānta represents the later stage, of the development of the same thought.

SECTION V

Vijñānavāda and Vedānta

Sharma states that it has already been proved (in the preceding chapter) that Vijñānavāda is neither subjective idealism, nor does it advocate the reality of merely momentary ideas: it is **absolute idealism**. The theory of momentariness is applied to phenomena only. Reality is declared to be Absolute Consciousness, which is the permanent background of all changing phenomena.

Roots in the Upaniṣads

This doctrine clearly has its essential roots in Upaniṣadic philosophy. The *parikalpita*, *paratantra* and *pariṇiṣpanna* of Vijñānavāda correspond to the *pratibhāsa*, *vyavahāra* and *paramārtha* of Vedānta. Vijñānavāda and Vedānta both agree in maintaining that Reality is Absolute Consciousness, the permanent background of all changing phenomena, which ultimately transcends the very trinity of knowledge, knower and known. Everything — the subject as well as the object — is its mere appearance.

Table of Terminological Equivalences

The Tathāgata-garbha or Ālaya-vijñāna of the Laṅkāvatāra, the Viśuddhātman or Mahātman or Paramātman of Asaṅga, the Vijñāptimātrā or Dharmakāya of Vasubandhu, and the Ātman or Brahman of Vedānta are, Sharma argues, essentially the same pure and permanent self-luminous Consciousness. Vasubandhu's system in particular maps onto Vedānta term for term:

Vasubandhu's Vijñānavāda	Vedāntic equivalent
Vijñāptimātra	Ātman / Brahman
Ālaya-vijñāna	Īśvara
Kliṣṭa-manovijñāna	Jīva
Viśaya-vijñapti	Jagat
Pariṇāma	Vivarta

The Laṅkāvatāra's Attempted Distinction — and Its Refutation

When the Laṅkāvatāra tries to distinguish its own Tathāgatagarbha or Ālayavijñāna from the 'non-Buddhistic' Ātman, the essential difference it points to is this: the former transcends all categories of intellect (*nirvikalpa*) and is to be directly realized through Spiritual Experience (*nirābhāsaprajñā-gochara*), while the latter clings to the category of affirmation.

Laṅkāvatāra, pp. 77–79.

But this distinction, Sharma argues, is **superficial and false**. The Ātman equally transcends all the categories of intellect (*nirguṇa* and *nirvikalpa*), and is equally to be directly realized through immediate experience (*jñāna*), exactly as the Tathāgatagarbha

is. The Ātman does not cling to the category of affirmation; no category can adequately describe it. When it is said that the Ātman is Pure Existence, what is meant is only that, though the Ātman cannot be strictly grasped by the category of 'existence,' when we describe it from the phenomenal point of view we must avoid nihilism and say that the Ātman exists by itself and in its own right, because it is self-luminous Consciousness.

Gauḍapāda's Debt to Vijñānavāda

We have seen that even Śaṅkara admits that Gauḍapāda accepts the arguments of Vijñānavāda to prove that the world is ultimately unreal, since it cannot exist independently of, and outside, Consciousness. Gauḍapāda is profoundly under the influence of Vijñānavāda. We have also seen that real Vijñānavāda, like real Śūnyavāda, is only **avoided**, not refuted, by Śaṅkara: his criticism of the so-called 'Vijñānavāda' is really the criticism of the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school alone. Śaṅkara's criticism of real Vijñānavāda — and this criticism applies to some extent to Gauḍapāda as well — loses much of its force for two reasons:

- Vijñānavāda and Gauḍapāda do not deny the objectivity of the external world, since they maintain that objects do appear as objects to the knowing subject; and
- they hold self-luminous consciousness to be the permanent background of all phenomena. They distinguish between the *parikalpita* and the *paratantra*, and when they place the dream state and the waking state almost on a par, they do so only to emphasize the ultimate unreality of the world.

The Real Difference Between Vijñānavāda and Śaṅkara

The main difference, therefore, between Vijñānavāda on the one hand and Śaṅkara and his followers on the other, is that the latter emphasize the empirical reality of the world and emphatically distinguish the dream state from the waking state, and that they prove the ultimate unreality of the world not by saying that it does not exist outside thought, but by saying, like Śūnyavāda, that it is false because it is relative and can be described neither as existent, nor as non-existent, nor as both. This view, Sharma reminds us, was already presented by Gauḍapāda himself. The advance made by Śaṅkara and his followers over Śūnyavāda and Gauḍapāda consists in the development of the view that *Avidyā* or *Māyā* is a **positive material stuff of Ignorance** which baffles all description.

Māṇḍūkya-Kārikā-Bhāṣya, IV, 28.

SECTION VI

Svatantra-Vijñānavāda and Vedānta

The only fundamental and most vital difference between this school and Vijñānavāda proper is that this school **degrades the permanent Consciousness** of Vijñānavāda to a series of momentary *vijñānas*. Reality, according to it, is a momentary *vijñāna* only — the unique momentary point-instant of Consciousness. It is under the name of ‘Vijñānavāda’ that Śāṅkara really criticizes this school — and, Sharma notes, unlike his dismissal of real Śūnyavāda and real Vijñānavāda, this criticism “is perfectly valid.” A momentary idea can be neither self-luminous, nor can it ideate itself. The reality of the permanent self-luminous Self, which is Pure Consciousness, must therefore be admitted.

Symmetry of Dialectical Refutations

Sharma points out the enormous similarities between the arguments for the refutation of other systems given by Dharmakīrti, Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla on the one hand, and the arguments for the refutation of those very same systems advanced by Śāṅkara and the Post-Śāṅkarites on the other. Vedānta does not reject the criticism levelled by the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins against other systems, so far as that criticism does not militate against Vedānta's own doctrine. Vedānta criticizes only their theory of momentary *vijñānas*, and their view that the external world is unreal because it is a mere projection of momentary consciousness — a view which “well smacks of subjectivism” once consciousness itself is reduced to momentary ideas.

The Argument Turned Back on Its Authors

Vedānta points out that the very arguments which the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins advance against permanent consciousness are, in fact, more applicable to their own momentary consciousness. To take Sharma's own example: if bondage and liberation are impossible when consciousness is treated as permanent, they are impossible *a fortiori* when consciousness is taken to be momentary. Vedānta accepts that Consciousness is self-luminous and that it ultimately transcends the subject-object duality and the very trinity of knower, known and knowledge. But from the empirical standpoint, Vedānta stresses, it is far better to describe Reality as Permanent and Pure Consciousness — which is at once Pure Existence and Pure Bliss — than to call it momentary, for whatever is momentary is miserable and self-contradictory. A momentary *vijñāna* can be neither self-luminous, nor can it ideate itself: it requires the Pure Self, which is Pure Consciousness, in order to be known at all.

Mutual Admissions of ‘Very Little Error’

Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla themselves confess that the view of the followers of the Upaniṣads — i.e., of Gauḍapāda and others — is very much similar to their own, and that it contains very little error, its only fault being that it declares Consciousness to be permanent.

teṣām alpāparādhā tu darśanam nityoktitaḥ, Tattva-saṅgraha, K. 330.

Vedānta, Sharma observes, may well rejoin in exactly the same coin: the view of the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins is very much similar to Vedānta; it contains very little error; its only fault is that it declares consciousness to be momentary.

teṣām alpāparādhā tu darśanam kṣaṇikoktitaḥ — Sharma's own deliberate mirroring of the Buddhist verse above.

SECTION VII

Nairātmyavāda (The No-Soul Theory)

Sharma now turns to the two theories that are “generally said” to be the vital, distinguishing marks separating Buddhism from Vedānta: Nairātmyavāda, and Kṣaṇa-bhaṅga-vāda, the theory of Momentariness. This section states his own view of the first.

The Central Thesis

Sharma's central claim is bold: **Buddhism, by Nairātmyavāda, does not deny the existence of the true Ātman**, the Pure Self which is Pure Consciousness and which is the only Reality. What Buddhism denies is the empirical ego. Buddhism takes the word ‘Ātman’ in the sense of the individual ego-complex, or the *jīvātman* — a product of beginningless *Avidyā*, *Māyā* or *Vāsanā*, and associated with the *Antaḥkaraṇa* or the *Buddhi*. The Buddha and the Mahāyānists have found it easy to repudiate this Ātman (the *jīva*), while at the same time accepting its empirical reality. It is, in fact, ‘the self of straw’ which they have erected simply to demolish it afterwards.

The **real self** is untouched by their criticism. They have, in one sense or another, either implicitly or explicitly, always accepted its reality. It is called — not generally Ātman, but *Bodhi*, *Prajñā*, *Chitta*, *Bodhi-chitta*, *Tattva*, *Vijñāna*, *Chittamātra*, *Vijñānamātra*, *Vijñāptimātra*, *Tathatā*, *Tathāgatagarbha*, *Dharmadhātu*, *Dharma-kāya*, or *Buddhakāya*. Āśvaghoṣa calls it Ātman also. Asaṅga calls it *Shuddhātman*, *Mahātman* and *Paramātman*. Even Śāntarakṣita calls it *Viśuddhātman*.

Saundarananda, XIV, 52 (Āśvaghoṣa); *Mahāyānasūtrālaṅkāra*, XIV, 37, and IX, 23 (Asaṅga); *Tattva-saṅgraha*, 3535 (Śāntarakṣita).

The Historical Irony

Sharma calls it “a great irony of fate” that the Buddhists and the Vedāntins fought against each other over this issue: Nairātmyavāda has been horribly misunderstood both by the Buddhists and by the Vedāntins — and the Buddha and the Buddhists themselves were greatly responsible for creating this misunderstanding.

How the Misunderstanding Arose

The Upaniṣads had repeatedly used the word Ātman as a synonym of Reality. The Buddha admitted this same Reality and termed it *Bodhi* or *Prajñā*. But instead of frankly identifying his *Bodhi* with the Upaniṣadic Ātman, the Buddha degraded ‘Ātman’ to the level of the *jīva* and easily condemned it as unreal. Sharma recalls the famous saying of Yājñavalkya — that the husband, the wife, the children, worldly objects and all things are loved, not for their own sake, but for the sake of the Ātman. Perhaps, he suggests, the Buddha wrongly took ‘Ātman’ in the sense of the ‘I’ and the ‘mine’ — which is indeed the cause of attachment and bondage. He therefore condemned it as an unreal thing, ‘imagined only by the dull.’

kevalo paripūro bāladdhammo, *Majjhimanikāya*, I, 1, 2.

Love for the Ātman, so (mis)understood, is likened to the blind passion of a foolish lover for the most beautiful damsel (*janapada-kalyāṇī*) — a lover who, as the Dīghanikāya represents it, knows nothing whatsoever of her existence, residence, colour, size or age.

Universal Denial of the Empirical Self, School by School

The Hīnayānists denied the self altogether: Nāgasena tells Milinda that the so-called self is nothing apart from fleeting ideas. The Mahāyāna-sūtras, the Śūnyavādins, the Vijñānavādins, and the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins all likewise take the word 'Ātman' in the sense of the notion of the 'I' and the vainglory of the 'Mine', and condemn it as ultimately unreal — this is what *Dharma-nairātmya* means: that all objective existents are unreal. Sharma marshals the chorus of authorities in full:

- **Nāgārjuna** declares that the self is neither identical with nor different from the five *skandhas*. When the 'I' and the 'mine' cease, the cycle of birth-and-death comes to a standstill.

Mādhyamika-Kārikā, X, 15; and XVIII, 4.

- **Āryadeva** says that in the beginning, evil should be avoided; in the middle, the Ātman should be viewed as unreal; and in the end, everything phenomenal should be taken to be unreal.

Chatuḥśataka, verse 190.

- **Candrakīrti** declares Ātman to be the cause of all sufferings and demerits, and says that a Yogī should deny its ultimate reality.

Madhyamakāvatāra, as quoted in *Mādhyamika-Vṛtti*, p. 340.

- **Śāntideva** says that just as, when one goes on taking off the layers of a plantain trunk or an onion, nothing will remain, so, similarly, when one goes on examining the self, ultimately it will be found to be nothing.

Bodhicaryāvatāra, IX, 75.

- **Asaṅga** says that all suffering is due to the ego, and the ego itself is due to beginningless ignorance; there is no self as a substance, nor even as a subject.

Mahāyānasūtrālaṅkāra, XI, 47; XVIII, 77, 92-103.

- **Vasubandhu** says that Consciousness transcends the duality of the subject and the object, both of which are ultimately unreal.

Viṃśatikā, 9 and 10.

- **Dharmakīrti** regards the self as the root cause of attachment and misery: as long as one is attached to the Ātman, so long will one revolve in the cycle of birth-and-death.

Pramāṇavārtika, II, 201, 213, 219.

- **Śāntarakṣita** clearly states that Consciousness, when associated with the notion of the ego, is called Ātman; it has only empirical reality; ultimately it denotes nothing.

Tattva-saṅgraha, 204.

Thus, right from the Buddha himself to Śāntarakṣita, the word Ātman is, in this line of usage, generally taken in the sense of the empirical ego, and its ultimate reality is

denied. It is variously called Ātman, Pudgala, Sattva, or Satkāya.

But the Pure Self, as Pure Consciousness, Is Always the Ultimate Reality

It is, Sharma insists, very important to remember that the Pure Self, which is Pure Consciousness, is always admitted by Buddhism to be the ultimate Reality. The Buddha himself identified Reality with *Bodhi* or *Prajñā*. The Tathatā of Aśvaghoṣa is Ālayavijñāna, or Absolute Consciousness. The Mahāyāna-sūtras identify Reality with Consciousness and call it *Prapañcasūnya*, *Atarkya*, *Sarvavāgviṣayātīta*, *Advaya*, *Achintya*, *Anakṣara*, *Anabhilāpya*, *Atyanta-viśuddha*, and *Pratyātmavedya*.

It is significant that, though Reality is not generally called Ātman in these texts, it is sometimes described as **Brahman**. The Aṣṭasāhasrikā tells us that all things are such that they neither come in nor go out; they are free from attachment and detachment; they are undefiled, unattached and uncontaminated, because they are of the very nature of Brahman — and that for supreme enlightenment one dwells in Brahman. The Śatasāhasrikā and the Lalitavistara describe Reality as Full of Bliss in the beginning, the middle and the end — One, Full, Pure, and the Abode of Brahman. The Saddharmapuṇḍarīka says that one who truly follows the teaching of the Buddha ever dwells in the Brahman, the Absolute, the Pure, the Calm, the Blissful and the Undefiled. Asaṅga likewise says that by becoming one with the Pure Spirit, one realizes the last, the fourth meditation, and then one ever dwells in the blissful Brahman.

Aṣṭasāhasrikā, p. 34; *Śatasāhasrikā*, p. 1460; *Lalitavistara*, p. 3; *Saddharmapuṇḍarīka*, p. 118.

Nāgārjuna's definition of Reality as the non-dual Absolute, Calm, Blissful and beyond all plurality applies to Pure Consciousness alone; he openly identifies Reality with Pure Consciousness, and says that the empirical ego must embrace Pure Consciousness in order to be transformed into Reality. Āryadeva says that the Jewel of the Self is absolutely pure and self-luminous, and appears impure only on account of ignorance — just as a white crystal appears coloured on account of a coloured object placed near it. Śāntideva says that the True Self, which is Pure Consciousness or *Bodhichitta*, can transform an impure mortal into a pure Buddha. The Laṅkāvatāra identifies Reality with the Tathāgatagarbha or Ālayavijñāna. Asaṅga says that the *Chitta*, or the Pure Self, is by its very nature self-luminous (*prakṛtiprabhāsvara*), and that all impurities are adventitious — he calls it *Shuddhātman*, *Mahātman* and *Paramātman*. Vasubandhu says that ultimate Reality is *Vijñāptimātra*, or Absolute Consciousness. Dharmakīrti says that Reality is Consciousness, which is beyond all words, names and concepts. Śāntarakṣita says that Consciousness is self-luminous and free from all impositions; it is one without a second. True knowledge consists in the realization of the Pure Self (*viśuddhātma-darśana*).

Mahāyānasūtrālaṅkāra, VII, 2-3; *Ratnāvalī*, I, 45, 60; *Chittaviśuddhiprakaraṇa*, 27-28; *Bodhicharyāvatāra*, I, 10; *Mahāyānasūtrālaṅkāra*, XIII, 19; *ibid.*, pp. 37-38; *Pramāṇavārtikā*, 88, 93; *Tattvasaṅgraha*, 3535.

Sharma's Concluding Equation

We thus see that Buddhism generally means, by *Jīvātman* or *Buddhi* or *Chitta* or *Antaḥkaraṇa*, what Vedānta also means by these terms. And, on the other hand,

Buddhism generally means by *Chitta* or *Vijñāna* or *Vijñapti* or *Bodhi* or *Prajñā* what Vedānta means by *Ātman* or *Brahman* or *Samvit* or *Chit*. Thus the Vedāntic Ātman generally becomes the Buddhistic Chitta, and the Vedāntic Chitta generally becomes the Buddhistic Ātman.

Had the Buddha refrained from committing an error of commission — degrading the Upaniṣadic Ātman to the level of the empirical ego — and also an error of omission — not identifying his *Bodhi* or *Prajñā* with the Upaniṣadic Ātman or Brahman — the age-old battle regarding Nairātmyavāda, fought without any reasonable ground by the Buddhists and the Vedāntins on the soil of Indian Philosophy, would have been surely avoided.

SECTION VIII

Kṣaṇa-bhaṅga-vāda (The Theory of Momentariness)

The theory of Momentariness, Sharma argues, **loses all its force and significance** in Buddha, Āśvaghoṣa, Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda, since in each of these it is applied to phenomena only. It presents a real problem only in Hīnayāna and in the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school.

Upaniṣadic Roots of the Perception of Misery and Flux

The Upaniṣads had already recognized the misery and momentariness of this world. Nachiketā kicked away wealth, land, women, sons, grandsons, music, dance and long life, saying that these things simply wear away the senses. Maitreyī, unlured by wealth, told Yājñavalkya: ‘What shall I do with that by which I cannot become immortal?’ The Buddha, too, was deeply moved by the misery of old age, illness and death, and he declared all world-objects to be momentary. The Hīnayānists, in their zeal, over-emphasized the dark side of the picture and unreservedly declared everything, without any exception, to be merely momentary.

The Sugata's Own Testimony Against Unqualified Momentariness

But these very people who boasted that the doctrine of momentariness (*kṣaṇikāḥ sarvasaṃskārāḥ*) is ‘the roaring of the Sugata-lion’ (*saugata-siṃhanāda*) forgot that it was the Sugata (Buddha) himself who proclaimed: the very fact that things in this world appear to be born, to be changing, to be made, and to be perishable, logically implies that there is a Reality which is Unborn, Immortal, Uncreated and Imperishable.

yasmā cha kho bhikkhave! atthi ajātam amatam akatam asaṅkhatam tasmā jātassa matassa katassa saṅkhatassa nissareṇam paññāya, Udāna, 73 Sutta.

They also forgot that it was the Sugata himself who called his Enlightenment ‘the Middle Path’, which transcended both the ‘ends’ of the intellect — including momentariness **and** permanence.

Āśvaghoṣa's and Śūnyavāda's Correction

Āśvaghoṣa realized this. He reaffirmed that everything phenomenal is momentary, fleeting and deceptive; but he proclaimed the Tathatā to be beyond all categories — neither momentary nor permanent, though phenomenally it must be called permanent. Śūnyavāda does the same thing: the ‘Madhyamamārga’ is a path which at once transcends both the extremes as well as the middle.

Samādhirāja-sūtra, p. 30.

The Laṅkāvatāra likewise declares its Ālayavijñāna to be beyond all categories. Asaṅga emphasizes the momentariness of all phenomena, but maintains that Reality is the permanent background of all changing phenomena. Vasubandhu's Vijñāptimātra is openly declared to be permanent, non-dual and blissful. Sthiramati says that whatever is momentary is misery, and whatever is permanent is bliss. The theory of Momentariness is thus applied to phenomena only.

Trimśikā-Bhāṣya, p. 44.

The Svatantra-Vijñānavāda Revival, and Its Refutation

In the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda, the theory is revived and is applied to Reality also. Reality is declared to be **a unique momentary point-instant of Consciousness**. “The Criticism of this school by Chandrakīrti and Śaṅkara,” Sharma states plainly, “is fully justified.”

SECTION IX

A Brief Historical Survey of Buddhism and Vedānta**The Common Fountainhead**

The Upaniṣads, Sharma states, are the fountainhead of all Indian Philosophy. The Buddha did not preach anything absolutely new. He was disgusted with the orthodox Vedic ritual, with the sacrifices in which animals were butchered, with the rigidity of the caste system, and with the supremacy of the Brāhmaṇdom. Yet the Buddha himself speaks in very high and respectable terms about a true Brāhmaṇa, whom he regards as an ideal saint who has done away with all sins and ignorance and who shines with the light of pure wisdom.

Suttanipāta, 35.

In the doctrines of the Buddha there was nothing that would seriously militate against Upaniṣadic philosophy; it was, in fact, based upon it. But after the death of the Buddha, the Hīnayānists misunderstood his teachings. Proclaiming that the No-soul theory and the theory of Universal Momentariness were the corner-stones of Buddhism, they reduced mind to fleeting ideas and matter to fleeting sensations.

The Mahāyāna Reaction

This brought a vehement protest from Aśvaghoṣa and from the Mahāyāna-sūtras. The Sarvāstivādin and others were dubbed 'Hīnayānists': they were either śrāvakas, or laymen, or, at best, Pratyekabuddhas — men of inferior intellect who could not understand the real teaching of the Buddha, which was meant for the Mahāyānist Bodhisattvas. Aśvaghoṣa interpreted Buddha in the light of the Upaniṣads and declared Reality to be Pure Existence, Pure Consciousness and Pure Bliss — all in one.

Timeline

Century	Figures / Development
2nd c.	Nāgārjuna synthesizes the scattered doctrines of the Mahāyāna-sūtras; work carried on by his disciple Āryadeva. Śūnyavāda brings Buddhism closer to Vedānta.
4th c.	Asaṅga and Vasubandhu agree with Śūnyavāda that Reality is devoid of all plurality and that all phenomena are mere appearances, but develop the (not-yet-fully-developed) view that Reality is Pure Consciousness. Vijñānavāda brings Buddhism still closer to Vedānta.
5th c.	Dignāga, seeing that Vasubandhu had merged Buddhism in Vedānta and disliking it, turns to Hīnayāna for inspiration and revives Momentariness — applying it, fatefully, to Ultimate Reality itself. Founds the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school of Buddhist logic.

Century	Figures / Development
6th c.	Gauḍapāda, the first systematic exponent of Advaita Vedānta, openly bases his philosophy on the Upaniṣads while absorbing the best of Nāgārjuna and Vasubandhu. Bhāviviveka (junior contemporary) recognizes Gauḍapāda's impartial spirit but founds Svatantra-Mādhyaṃika; Buddhapālita founds Prāsaṅgika-Mādhyaṃika in response.
7th c.	Candrakīrti and Śāntideva (Śūnyavāda), Dharmakīrti (Svatantra-Vijñānavāda) and Kumārila (Mīmāṃsā) contend amid rising Brāhmaṇical revival and Buddhist institutional decline. None bridges the Gauḍapāda chasm; Dharmakīrti widens it.
8th c.	Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla refute Nyaya/Mīmāṃsā attacks but repeat Dignāga's error. Sectarian polemics peak; Buddhism is ousted from India; Śaṅkara, in the same century, delivers the final death-blow to Buddhist philosophy.

Dignāga's Fateful Turn (5th Century) — Discussed in Full

At that time, Brāhmaṇism was undergoing a rapid revival, and the rivalry between Buddhism and Brāhmaṇism was increasing. Dignāga saw clearly that Vasubandhu had merged Buddhism in Vedānta. He did not like it. In his mistaken zeal to distinguish Buddhism from Vedānta, he turned to Hīnayāna for his inspiration and fell back on the theory of Momentariness.

Vasubandhu was so revered, and so famous — he had the unique distinction of being called 'the second Buddha' — that Dignāga did not think it proper to challenge his authority openly. Saying that, so far as ultimate reality was concerned, he agreed with Vasubandhu, Dignāga busied himself instead with the revival of Buddhist logic; he wanted to dilute the Absolute Idealism of Vasubandhu with the Critical Realism of the Sautrāntika. He ruthlessly criticized the Naiyāyikas, whom he called 'bunglers in logic,' and founded the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school of Buddhist logic. There was no harm in this, Sharma says — Dignāga was perfectly free to do it, *provided he did not touch ultimate reality*.

His **greatest error** lay in declaring Ultimate Reality to be an absolutely dissimilar particular, a unique 'thing-in-itself,' which is a unique momentary point-instant of Consciousness. He agreed with Vasubandhu that Reality was Consciousness — but his error lay in declaring this Consciousness itself to be momentary. Thus Dignāga, on the one hand, paid lip-homage to Vasubandhu, while, on the other, he really undermined the very root of Vasubandhu's philosophy.

Dignāga, therefore, is the first Buddhist philosopher who is really responsible for the downfall of Buddhism — at least of Buddhist philosophy. There were, of course, other social, economic, political and religious causes as well. But the new interpretation of the theory of Momentariness, and its application even to the Ultimate Reality, created a philosophical chasm between Buddhism and Vedānta. Dignāga was the first man who sowed the poisonous seed which grew into a plant in Dharmakīrti and bore fruit in Śāntarakṣita, and led to the doom of Buddhist philosophy in India. Had Dignāga tried to develop, or even to explain, the philosophy of Vasubandhu, this tragedy would certainly have been averted.

Gauḍapāda (6th Century) and the 'Crypto-Buddhist' Charge

In the sixth century came Gauḍapāda, the first known systematic exponent of Advaita Vedānta. He openly based his philosophy on the Upaniṣads. The influence of Nāgārjuna and Vasubandhu on Gauḍapāda is clear; the phrases and terms he used were not the monopoly of any particular school — they were the common heritage of the age's philosophical language.

Gauḍapāda is charged with being a 'crypto-Buddhist.' If this charge means that Gauḍapāda was really a Buddhist who merely pretended to be a Vedāntin, Sharma calls it foolish. If, on the other hand, it means that Gauḍapāda was influenced by Buddhism, it is correct. Those who dub him a crypto-Buddhist tend to suggest that he had a definite leaning towards Buddhism and only outwardly professed to be a Vedāntin. **Their error lies in the mistaken belief that Buddhism and Vedānta are two absolutely opposed systems** — a belief to which, Sharma says, his entire treatment in this chapter gives "a death-blow."

It is a great irony of fate that Buddhism and Vedānta — though they are the offsprings of the same mother, the Upaniṣadic Philosophy; though they are fed by the same ideology; though they are nurtured by the same methodology; though they are brought up in the same ontology; and though they grow up in the same philosophical atmosphere — yet the Buddhist should regard the Vedāntin as a pagan (*tīrthika*), and the Vedāntin should regard the Buddhist as an alien (*bāhya*)! The Hīnayāna and the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda are philosophically responsible for this grave misunderstanding. Fortunately, the Hīnayānists were corrected by the Mahāyānists; but, unfortunately, no great Buddhist was ever born to correct the error of Svatantra-Vijñānavāda. If one is really fond of this 'Prachchhanna' (crypto-) terminology, Sharma quips, then instead of dubbing Gauḍapāda a 'Prachchhanna-Bauddha,' it would be far more appropriate to dub the Śūnyavādins and the Vijñānavādins as 'Prachchhanna-Vedāntins.'

Gauḍapāda represents the best that is in Nāgārjuna and Vasubandhu. While the Buddhists either kept indifferent, or outwardly professed to be, if not exactly the opponents of Vedānta, at least the followers of a different faith, it was the mission of Gauḍapāda to convince people — including the Buddhists — that his own philosophy, and the Buddhist philosophy so far as it agreed with his own, were directly rooted in the Upaniṣads. Gauḍapāda's impartial spirit is highly admirable; his attitude towards the Buddha and the Buddhists is one of love and even of respect. He extended his hand of friendship towards the Buddhists — but, unfortunately, the Buddhists did not respond.

Bhāvaviveka, who flourished in the sixth century and was a junior contemporary of Gauḍapāda, quotes approvingly from him in the *Tarkajvālā*; he is the first Buddhist to recognize Gauḍapāda's impartial spirit. But he, too, instead of directing his energy towards bridging the chasm created by Dignāga, drew his inspiration from Dignāga, and, in his zeal to found a new school, founded the Svatantra-Mādhyamika school, which sought to support Śūnyavāda by means of independent logical arguments. Against this school, Buddhapālita founded the Prāsaṅgika-Mādhyamika school, which rejected all independent arguments.

The Seventh Century: Escalating Antagonism, and Every Missed Opportunity

The seventh century gave rise to the Sūnyavādins Candrakīrti and Śāntideva, to the Svatantra-Vijñānavādin Dharmakīrti, and to the Mīmāṃsaka Kumārila. Brāhmaṇa religion, culture and philosophy were undergoing a vigorous revival, and the antagonism between Buddhism and Brāhmaṇism had increased greatly. Buddhistic Tantra, degenerating into Vāma-mārga, was becoming increasingly prevalent. Owing to changed economic, social and political conditions, Buddhism was losing the patronage of the wealthy; under the supervision of a perverted monkdom, the Buddhist monasteries were rapidly becoming nurseries of corruption. These conditions badly needed a Buddhist scholar who could bridge the gulf between Buddhism and Vedānta — but, unfortunately, none rose to the occasion.

- **Candrakīrti** bitterly criticized the Svatantra-Mādhyamika school of Bhāvaviveka and the Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school of Dignāga — but he, too, failed to imbibe the spirit of Gauḍapāda. Though there were enormous similarities between Gauḍapāda and Nāgārjuna, Candrakīrti completely ignored Gauḍapāda, and did positively nothing to bridge the chasm between Buddhism and Vedānta.
- **Śāntideva** felt it was not wise to keep silent on, or leave undeveloped, the conception of Reality, and therefore fervently extolled the *Bodhicitta*. But he too failed to remark openly that Buddhism and Vedānta were the offsprings of the same philosophy.
- **Dharmakīrti** represents the greatest missed opportunity of all. The need of the hour was a staunch Vijñānavādin who could revive and develop the philosophy of Vasubandhu and who could boldly proclaim it to be based on the Upaniṣads. Instead, Dharmakīrti, the Svatantra-Vijñānavādin, glorified the error of Dignāga and harped on separatistic tunes. The Naiyāyika and the Mīmāṃsaka were the two major opponents of Buddhism at the time; Dharmakīrti ruthlessly criticized both — which, Sharma notes, was no crime in itself, since Śaṅkara and Sureśvara too bitterly criticized Mīmāṃsā, and nothing untoward happened to them for it. Dharmakīrti ought instead to have accepted Vasubandhu's philosophy, openly declared it to be based on the Upaniṣads, and then busied himself with his logic and his criticism of Nyaya, Mīmāṃsā and the other schools. As a genius, he ought to have corrected Dignāga's mistake by ousting the theory of Momentariness from the realm of Reality and restricting its application to phenomena only. Had he done that, Buddhism would not have met the fate it did. But what he actually did was to widen the gulf between Buddhism and Vedānta created by Dignāga, and thus to hasten the doom of Buddhism in India.

Dharmakīrti's attack on Mīmāṃsā was so damaging that it provoked his contemporary Kumārila to write his voluminous *Śloka-Vārtika*, to refute Buddhism and defend Mīmāṃsā. Kumārila is, in fact, the first man who dealt effective blow after blow against Buddhism.

The Eighth Century: Śāntarakṣita, Kamalaśīla, and the Final Blow

The attacks of the Naiyāyikas and of Kumārila gave rise, in the eighth century, to Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla, who extensively refuted them and criticized all the other

schools prevalent in their time. Like Dignāga and Dharmakīrti before them, they too paid lip-homage to Vasubandhu, saying that so far as ultimate reality was concerned they followed in his footsteps.

Tattva-saṅgraha, 2084.

But they, too, really undermined Vasubandhu's philosophy, repeating what Sharma calls the 'Himālayan blunder' of Dignāga. They admit that there are many similarities between Buddhism and Vedānta, and that the only error of Vedānta is that it declares Consciousness to be permanent. Vedānta, for its part, accepts their criticism of other schools so far as it does not violate the Vedāntic standpoint, and points out that a momentary *viññāna* cannot be called self-luminous or real — Consciousness must be called, at least empirically, permanent, for whatever is momentary is misery, and whatever is permanent is bliss. Dialecticians of the first rank as they undoubtedly were, Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla could have saved the situation from taking a worse turn.

The Degeneration into Sectarian Polemics

Perhaps the atmosphere was so full of hatred and animosity that they could not even think of bridging the gulf. Śāntarakṣita himself remarks that learned Brāhmaṇas have great respect for the Buddha, that a true Brāhmaṇa is one who has removed all sins (*vāhitapāpatvād brāhmaṇaḥ*), and that such Brāhmaṇas are to be found only in the religion of the Enlightened Sage.

Tattva-saṅgraha, 3512, 3589.

But such things receded into the background, while dogmatic arguments and repartees increasingly came to the forefront. The Mīmāṃsaka argued: because the Buddha taught his doctrine to fools and Śūdras, it is clear that his teaching was false, like a counterfeit coin.

Tattva-saṅgraha, 3227.

In fact — the Mīmāṃsaka continued — just as a herbal medicine which has been touched by the teeth of a mongoose removes, even when playfully used, all poison from a limb bitten by a snake, similarly any argument, whether Vedic or secular, emanating from the mouth of a follower of the Veda, removes all the poisonous misconceptions of Buddhism.

Tattva-saṅgraha, 3155-6.

And the Buddhist retorted in kind: a long time has passed, and women are fickle by nature, so it is very difficult to ascertain the purity of the Brāhmaṇa race. The feeble and foolish Brāhmaṇa, at the very sight of the poisonous eyes of a Buddhist-snake, cannot even breathe, much less think of confronting it. Even a reasonable argument from the mouth of a follower of the Veda looks as ugly as a necklace, or a string of beads, placed on the feet.

Tattva-saṅgraha, 3579; and 3376-7.

The result of all this, Sharma observes drily, was that Buddhism could not resist the onslaught of Brāhmaṇism and was ousted from the land of its birth. Śāntarakṣita himself was forced to retire to Tibet, where he took his disciple Kamalaśīla too. And with them virtually ended Buddhistic philosophy in India — though isolated Buddhist

scholars continued to appear here and there up to a much later date.

Śaṅkara's Final Blow, and Why He Never Refuted *Real Śūnyavāda* or *Vijñānavāda*

Then came the great Śaṅkara, in that very eighth century, just after Śāntarakṣita: he gave the final death-blow to Buddhist philosophy. Śaṅkara, Sharma reminds us, was himself greatly influenced by Buddhism — but the vital error of the Svatantra-Vijñānavādins, together with the other things that had degraded Buddhism by then, transformed the love and respect that Gauḍapāda had once shown towards Buddhism into the outward animosity and hatred exhibited by Śaṅkara. Śaṅkara has nothing but bitter and strong remarks for Buddhism.

We have seen that Śaṅkara does not criticize real Śūnyavāda and real Vijñānavāda: Svatantra-Vijñānavāda is the only school of Mahāyāna he criticizes — and rightly refutes. Why did Śaṅkara not refute real Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda? Sharma offers two hypotheses:

- **Hypothesis one — unavailability of texts.** The mutual animosity, hatred and distrust between the two camps was such that the Buddhists kept their texts secret from non-Buddhists. (It is also said that Kumārila, in order to learn the essentials of Buddhism, first became a Buddhist himself and studied in a Buddhist monastery for years.) It may be, then, that the Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda texts simply were not available to Śaṅkara.
- **Hypothesis two — deliberate strategy (the more probable, on Sharma's own judgment).** Śaṅkara fully knew how similar Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda were to his own Vedānta — as evidenced by how faithfully and correctly he presented Sarvāstivāda and Svatantra-Vijñānavāda, the schools he did engage directly. It may well be that Śaṅkara knew that the differences between his Vedānta and real Śūnyavāda/Vijñānavāda were only differences of emphasis; that the best in them was already preserved in Gauḍapāda's philosophy and his own; and that their fundamental teachings could not be refuted, precisely because he himself accepted them. Śaṅkara's aim was to oust Buddhism, so he simply dismissed Śūnyavāda as nihilism, taking the word *śūnya* in its popular sense of negation, and avoided Vijñānavāda altogether by taking it exclusively in the sense of Svatantra-Vijñānavāda.

The Post-Śaṅkarites, and the Dawning Recognition

Most of the Post-Śaṅkarites, following Śaṅkara, do the same thing and repeat his arguments. But once Buddhism was ousted and the struggle had died down, people began to think about it more dispassionately. Thus we find some Post-Śaṅkarites remarking that if Śūnyavāda is not nihilism, they have no quarrel with it, since it is then simply merged in Vedānta; and that if Vijñānavāda is not the subjectivism which advocates the reality of momentary *vijñānas*, but is instead absolute idealism, they have no quarrel with it either, since it then also embraces Vedānta. We find, in the same school, an eminent figure like Śrīharṣa openly admitting the similarities between Buddhism and Vedānta.

Khaṇḍana, pp. 21, 31, 61.

Sharma's Final Statement

Even in the present time, Sharma concludes, Buddhism is generally misunderstood. This chapter has tried to clear away the misunderstandings about it, and has pointed out that throughout, it is rooted in Vedānta.

Mahāyāna Buddhism and Vedānta should now be viewed, not as two opposed systems, but only as different stages in the development of the same Upaniṣadic thought.